

The 2026 IRMAA Guide

Understanding Medicare's income-related surcharge — what triggers it, what it costs, and how to appeal it if your income has changed.

What Is IRMAA?

IRMAA stands for **Income-Related Monthly Adjustment Amount**. It's a surcharge the Social Security Administration adds on top of the standard Medicare Part B and Part D premiums for people whose income is above certain thresholds. It is not a tax, a penalty, or a reduction in benefits — it's simply a higher monthly premium tied to income.

IRMAA applies whether you have Original Medicare or a Medicare Advantage plan, and it applies separately to Part B and Part D. If you're married and both spouses are on Medicare, each spouse's premium is assessed individually — so a household can pay the surcharge twice.

How It's Calculated: The Two-Year Lookback

This is the detail that catches people off guard: your 2026 IRMAA is based on your **2024** tax return (Modified Adjusted Gross Income, or MAGI) — not your current income. So a big income year from two years ago — a Roth conversion, the sale of a home or stock, a final year of full-time work — can raise your premiums today, even if your income has since dropped.

IRMAA also works as a **cliff**, not a gradual phase-in. Earning \$1 over a threshold triggers the entire next tier's surcharge — not just a surcharge on the amount over the line. This is the single most common and most expensive surprise clients run into.

2026 Medicare Part B IRMAA Brackets

Based on 2024 MAGI. Standard Part B premium: \$202.90/month.

Individual Return	Joint Return	Married Filing Separately	Monthly Part B Premium
\$109,000 or less	\$218,000 or less	\$109,000 or less	\$202.90
\$109,001 – \$137,000	\$218,001 – \$274,000	N/A	\$284.10
\$137,001 – \$171,000	\$274,001 – \$342,000	N/A	\$405.80
\$171,001 – \$205,000	\$342,001 – \$410,000	N/A	\$527.50

Individual Return	Joint Return	Married Filing Separately	Monthly Part B Premium
\$205,001 – \$499,999	\$410,001 – \$749,999	\$109,001 – \$390,999	\$649.20
\$500,000 or more	\$750,000 or more	\$391,000 or more	\$689.90

2026 Medicare Part D IRMAA Brackets

This amount is added on top of your plan's own premium — same income tiers as Part B.

Individual Return	Joint Return	Married Filing Separately	Added to Plan Premium
\$109,000 or less	\$218,000 or less	\$109,000 or less	\$0.00
\$109,001 – \$137,000	\$218,001 – \$274,000	N/A	+\$14.50
\$137,001 – \$171,000	\$274,001 – \$342,000	N/A	+\$37.50
\$171,001 – \$205,000	\$342,001 – \$410,000	N/A	+\$60.40
\$205,001 – \$499,999	\$410,001 – \$749,999	\$109,001 – \$390,999	+\$83.30
\$500,000 or more	\$750,000 or more	\$391,000 or more	+\$91.00

How You Find Out You Owe IRMAA

You won't apply for IRMAA or choose it — the Social Security Administration determines it automatically using IRS tax data. If it applies to you, SSA mails a predetermination notice explaining the finding, followed by an initial determination notice with instructions on what to do if you believe it's incorrect. Keep both notices in a safe place.

How IRMAA Is Paid

If your Medicare premiums are already deducted from your Social Security or Railroad Retirement Board benefit, your IRMAA surcharge is deducted automatically the same way. If you don't have premiums deducted from a benefit payment, you'll receive a separate bill for the surcharge.

Can IRMAA Be Reduced or Appealed?

Yes — and this is where an agent can genuinely help. You can request that the SSA reconsider your determination if your income has changed due to a qualifying **life-changing event**, or if the income figure they used was wrong or outdated.

Qualifying life-changing events include:

- Death of a spouse
- Marriage
- Divorce or annulment
- Reduction or loss of work
- Loss of income-producing property (beyond your control)
- Loss or reduction of certain pension income
- An employer settlement payment (e.g. due to a bankruptcy or closure)

To request a reduction, file **Form SSA-44** (Medicare Income-Related Monthly Adjustment Amount – Life-Changing Event) with your local Social Security office, or call the SSA at 800-772-1213 to request a new income determination if your tax return was later amended or corrected.

Frequently Asked Questions

What is MAGI?

MAGI stands for Modified Adjusted Gross Income. It starts with your Adjusted Gross Income (AGI) from your tax return, then adds back a few items — most commonly tax-exempt interest (like municipal bond interest). For most retirees, MAGI is close to AGI, but it's what determines your IRMAA bracket, not your take-home income.

When should I appeal?

After you receive your IRMAA notice from Social Security (the initial determination notice) — that notice is what starts the clock and gives you the specifics of the determination you're appealing.

How should I appeal?

File Form SSA-44 (ssa.gov/forms/ssa-44.pdf). Bringing it in person to your local Social Security office is the best option — you can get same-day confirmation and ask questions on the spot. You can also mail it in, though it will take longer to process.

What if I sell a home, do a Roth conversion, or have another one-time event that raises my MAGI for a single year?

Those types of events typically don't qualify as a "life-changing event" for an appeal — but you can always try. The good news: Social Security re-assesses your income every year using your latest tax return, so if your income was only elevated for that one year, you'll typically only pay the higher premium for one year before it resets.

Will enrolling in a Medicare Advantage plan, including a \$0/month Part C plan, help me avoid IRMAA?

No. IRMAA is tied to Part B and Part D enrollment, not which plan type you choose. As long as you're enrolled in Part B and/or Part D — even through a Medicare Advantage plan with drug coverage (MAPD) — you'll still owe any applicable IRMAA surcharge on top of that plan.

Yearly Adjustments

IRMAA brackets are reviewed and adjusted for inflation each year (except the top bracket, which is fixed by law). Because the surcharge is based on a two-year-old tax return, a decision you make about income this year — a Roth conversion, a large capital gain — won't show up in your premiums until two years from now. This lookback is exactly why proactive income planning, done with your tax professional and Medicare agent working together, matters most in the years just before and during retirement.

Think you might be affected by IRMAA — or want a second look at a determination?

We help clients understand their Medicare costs and connect them with the right resources, at no cost.

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